

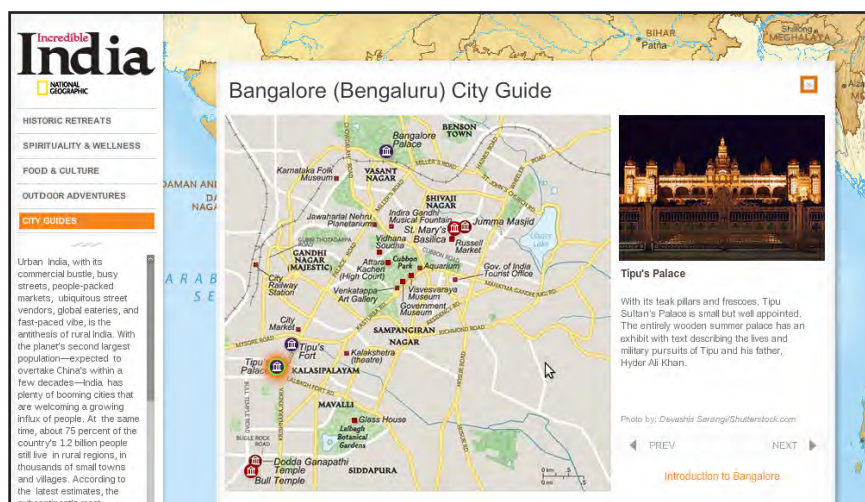


feature

Tip:

Even when you are at a particular place you can use GPRS on your phone to look up info on wiki travel

CONNECTIONS



Interactive live maps are available from a number of web sites.

Indiatravelog.com: this is an India specific travel web site that gives details of various holiday plans by theme. Their themes are quite extensive; ranging from adventure and wildlife to beaches and ayurvedic holidays. The site also claims to give free travel assistance by filling out an online form. You can ask their Tour Planner about prices, itinerary suggestions, bookings, etc.

Trivago.co.uk: as the URL suggests, this web site is aimed at a specific audience but nevertheless is a great resource to compare prices for hotels, browse the site for attractions, reviews and photos. It has an interactive Google powered map that lets you triangulate on an area and view the various options including hotel availability and attractions. You also have the option of entering a city and duration of holiday and you'll be presented with a list of hotels on the right. You also have the option of refining a search by price. When you click on the attractions tab in a particular city, you will have a sidebar to filter for events, nightclubs, museums etc. or pick specific places from a tag cloud of places and attractions. The best part is that all content is user generated.

Cultureholidays.com: again, an India specific site but probably targeted at foreigners. Still they've got some of the most innovative itinerary plans around. You get great package deals to check out and learn from. The web site has a long left panel with resources ranging from car rentals, useful tips, distance calculator, weather, and shopping. Apart from this you will also find innovative itineraries such as the Elephant Festival Tour, which is centred around the famous Jaipur festival.

travel.mapsofindia.com: a sub-site of mapsofindia.com, this is one terrific collection of information on almost any place imaginable in India. The detail is so great that this can actually be a one stop site for your

needs. For instance, click on the Travel to Goa link in the left side bar. You will find yourself with a multitude of in-depth details including a general roundup of attractions, ways to get there, fairs and festivals and destination guides.



Innovative itineraries at culture holidays

Worldtravelguide.net: ease of use and attention to detail separate this one from the rest. Additionally, the website is the most thorough we have come across in its approach. It's got travel guides to every country in the world as well as detailed city, ski, beach, cruise and airport guides. Click on Travel Essentials for world weather forecasts, a world clock, a World Events Guide, attraction guides, and more. First click a location from the map, and then you select the type of guide you're looking for to the right. Options include, country guides, beach guides, cruise guides etc.

Other notable mentions include **Idiscoverindia.com**, **Indianholiday.com** and **lonelyplanet.com** and **zoomtra.com**

Communities and forums

Travel communities and forums are a good way to get first hand info and also to interact with fellow travellers. **Indiamike.com** is a fairly popular Indian travel forum with a huge database of user generated information. You get to see reviews, read travelogues of people

within India, and also seek advice on almost anything even remotely connected to travelling. You have discussion threads on travel basics, states in India, cities, transportation, offbeat vacation ideas, and even a thread on itinerary advice. The itinerary advice incidentally has some 27,000 posts! Forums and communities are also a good place to get visa and passport advice too.

Part 2: Transportation

The mode of travel is a major concern while on a vacation. After you have planned out your itinerary, you should have a fair idea of what modes of travel you need to look into. For domestic travel you have road, rail and air as the main transport methods. For international travel flight is the only option, and since flying to Bangkok is cheaper than flying to Bangalore you shouldn't rule out international travel. So let's say you zero in on flight as your transport of choice for the first leg of your journey. Which websites will help you book a flight and what else is there to know? Travel web sites such as Travelocity, Yatra, Cleartrip or MakeMyTrip are good for getting consolidated info on flights, espe-



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cially international travel. They all follow a similar format which allows you to specify details such as destination, departure and arrival dates before searching for all available flight options. You can even filter the results by price, airline preference and timing preference. When it comes to domestic booking you can visit the carriers' web site directly to access better deals,

